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From the editor-in-chief

I have a special interest in education. I believe the future of this country depends on the quality of its educational institutions. Twenty years ago, I set up a not-for-profit educational trust and started a school (K-12) in Delhi called Vasant Valley. I had observed during my children's education at one of Delhi's leading schools how boring, burdensome and limited it was. The idea was to create a school where learning was fun, creative and developed the full personality of the child. I think we have succeeded in large measure but it has been an uphill struggle against mindless government regulations and judicial interventions. The attitude of the authorities is to reduce everything to the lowest common denominator. It's been a dispiriting experience. But that's another story.

However, in spite of islands of excellence like our IITs and IIMS, there is something rotten in the state of India's education—at every level. Only one in nine children who finishes school ends up in university. There is a huge shortage of educational institutions which is driving those cut-off percentages even higher. Multiple regulatory authorities that sit in judgement on our schools and colleges are out of line with the demands of modern education.

As many as 49 private universities have been given sanction since 2004 (compared to 44 in the previous 50 years), more than a few, it is now known, due to intense political lobbying and dubious considerations rather than the quality of education they were supposed to impart.

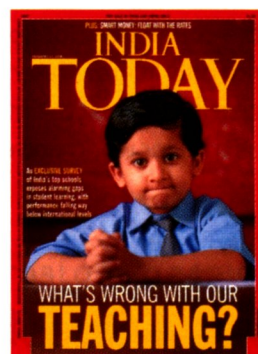
There is a shortage of teachers in our schools and colleges and even in the IITs which means that those who have managed to crack the institution's daunting entrance exam are still not getting the quality of education they deserve. Only one in four Indian graduates is deemed as employable and there is a desperate shortage of technical and vocational institutions which can meet the demand of India's growing economy and its subsequent expansion into a range of new sectors.

There have been many solutions offered to stem the rising tide of mediocrity that has swamped India's education system: setting up a statutory autonomous higher education commission, the privatisation and liberalisation of the education sector as well as the involvement of industry so that education and training can directly feed into jobs.

Our cover story this week looks at the reforms needed in the education sector and is put together by Managing Editor Raj Chengappa who is also the editor of our education magazine *Aspire*. He spoke to experts in the government and academia about just how India's education system can be reformed. Last week Union HRD Minister Kapil Sibal proposed some fairly radical ideas to reform and 'de-traumatise' the school system which was a hopeful sign after the somnolence of the previous occupant.

But I believe the time for incremental changes is long past. Our education system is the foundry where the workforce of the future is forged. It is the workforce that drives an economy. If India's workforce will prove inadequate in both quantity and quality, its impact on the ground in a few decades will be catastrophic. The crisis is severe and serious. Our response to it today must be radical and revolutionary.

(Aroon Purie)



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